Circle Internet Group (CRCL): 3Q26 EPS: Puts and takes; Top line & margin beat, vs. substantial 4Q26 QoQ RLDC margin step down guide

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CRCL reported 3Q26 EPS of 84c, above GSe/Visible Alpha Consensus Data estimate of 27c/34c[1], core EPS of 75c[2], vs. GSe/consensus like estimates of 45c/54c[3], and adj. EBITDA (ex. SBC) of $317mn, above GSe/the Street of $196mn/$206mn. We believe stock underperformance on the day, relative to other digital asset-adjacent stocks, reflects: 1) the quarterly revenue beat being largely driven by one-time ARC token pre-sale revenue, which we expect to be de minimis in 4Q26; 2) less 4Q26 USDC balance growth thus far, increasing uncertainty around the growth trajectory, at least in the near-term; and 3) company guidance suggesting a ~18pp 4Q26E QoQ stepdown in RLDC margins from recent partnership agreements to a level below consensus, and setting up a lower jumping off point into 2027. Constructively, management highlighted: 1) while EOP USD balances remained stable YoY, USDC transaction volume rose 49% YoY in 3Q26, underscoring growing utility and activity; 2) Circle Payment Network (CPN) continues to scale rapidly, with annualized payment volume surpassing $58bn at end-October, supported by strong financial institution adoption; and 3) robust early traction in Arc Mainnet since launch, with 100+ applications and ~$1.5bn of assets on chain. Against this: 1) USDC balance growth has slowed amid a softer digital asset market, with current USDC market cap 6% lower YoY; 2) the company expects its RLDC margin to decline in 4Q26 QoQ, as CRCL shares meaningful reserve economics with distribution partners, including its recently renewed agreement with Binance. Management guided to a 2026 RLDC margin ex. ARC presale proceeds at the midpoint of the previously disclosed guidance range of 38-40%. This implies a meaningful sequential RLDC margin step down (-570bps ex. ARC) to ~34% in 4Q26 (vs. the Street at 37.5% ex. ARC), as well as a lower out year runrate (we project 2027E/28E RLDC margins of 34.5%/33.5%); and 3) with unchanged 2026 other revenue guidance, and meaningfully higher ARC presale revenue in 3Q26, we see de minimis Arc presale revenue in 4Q26E, with a cumulative ~$60mn of Arc token presale revenue to be recognized across 4Q26E/2027E, likely mostly in 2027E. All in, factoring in lower USDC balances QTD and management commentary, our 2026E/27E/28E net revenue declines by 1%/17%/17%, with net revenue margin (or RLDC margin) changing by +0.2pp/-2.8pp/-2.6pp.

[1] Note: We calculate consensus EPS from consensus PnL components, vs. pulling consensus EPS estimate directly from data provider and assume consensus change in fair value of warrant liability equal to GSe.

[2] Note: Adjusting for below the line items, FV gain on convertible debt, warrant liability, embedded derivatives, and UST, excluding SBC, and normalizing the tax rate.

[3] excluding SBC, normalizing tax rate

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Quarterly total operating expenses were well-managed, at 1% below consensus, despite the top-line beat. However, management pointed toward the higher end of the unchanged adjusted operating expense guide ($570-585mn), reflecting costs associated with recent partnerships and platform investments, including sponsoring Chelsea Football Club (here). Given the quarterly results and commentary, our 2027E/28E company defined adjusted operating expenses rise by 4%/1%.

Based on the results, management commentary and the updated outlook, our 2026E/27E/28E adj. EPS falls by 3%/34%/28%. We increase our target P/E multiple on Q5-Q8 EPS to 34.0x (from 30.5x) to account for higher market multiples, resulting in our 12-month price target decreasing 10% to $81 (from $90).

- **Revenue:** Total net revenue of $453mn came in 32%/28% above GSe/consensus, with 11% higher gross revenue and 3% lower total distribution & other costs vs. GSe/Street, resulting in a RLDC margin of 52.4%, ~775bps/705bps better than GSe/consensus. However, the quarterly revenue beat was primarily driven by one-time Arc presale revenue, which has 100% revenue margins, and came in at $182mn, vs. $90mn for GSe/Street. Ex-Arc, the company realized other revenue of $25mn, down 25% QoQ, driven by fewer blockchain integration. All in, our 2026E/27E/28E total net revenue decreases by 1%/17%/17% - detail on moving pieces:
  - **Gross reserve income:** End-of-period USDC in circulation balances rose ~1% QoQ to $73.9bn (flat YoY). Despite flat balances, management highlighted strong USDC transaction volume growth of +49% YoY. Management remain constructive on long-term USDC adoption, reiterating their 40% through the cycle CAGR target, and noted increasing institutional adoption. Upon marking to market for lower USDC balances QTD in 4Q26, our 2026E/27E/28E gross reserve income falls by 2%/10%/10%.
  - **RLDC margin:** Excluding ARC presale revenue, the RLDC margin of 39.7% was down ~150bps QoQ. The company guided to the RLDC margin continuing to decline, as CRCL shares meaningful reserve economics with partners. 4Q26 represents the first full quarter incorporating the recently renewed agreement with Binance that appears to be RLDC margin-dilutive. Management reiterated its 41.7%-43.7% 2026E RLDC margin guidance, and pointed to a RLDC margin of ~39% excluding the ARC token presale, which implies a meaningful sequential step down to ~34% in 4Q26, which is below the Street at 37.5%. This sets up a lower 2027E exit run rate as well. As a result, our 2026E/27E/28E RLDC margins change by +0.2pp/-2.8pp/-2.6pp to 43.0%/34.5%/33.5%.
  - **Other revenue:** We expect de minimis ARC revenue in 4Q26E, given unchanged 2026 other revenue (incl. Arc) guidance of $310-330mn and the front-loaded realization of the ~$180mn of projected 2026E proceeds in 3Q26. Going forward, CRCL noted it will monetize the ARC blockchain from: 1) recurring staking rewards; 2) token sales with no associated costs; and 3) ecosystem incentives. However, ecosystem incentive revenue would be completely offset with related distribution costs, resulting in no impact to adj.

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EBITDA. Further, the company sees more blockchain integrations QoQ in 4Q26. As a result, our 2027E/28E other net revenue decreases by 21%/19%.

- **Expenses and margins:** Total operating expenses of $245mn were 1% below the Street, on 9% lower compensation, partially offset by 33%/22%/13% higher Marketing/IT infrastructure/D&A expenses (all vs. the Street), with adj. EBITDA margin of 69.9%, ~11pp better than consensus (~50% ex-ARC). The company reiterated the 2026 adjusted operating expense guide of $570-585mn, although noted it is tracking towards the high end of that range, driven by costs associated with partnerships and platform investments, including the recent sponsorship of the Chelsea Football Club for the 2026-27 season. All in, we increase our company defined adj. expenses by 4%/1% in 2027E/28E, with our 2026E/27E/28E adjusted EBITDA margins (ex. SBC) falling by 0.5pp/10.5pp/7.7pp to 54.9%/48.9%/58.0%.

Estimates/PT changes: Based on the results, and the updated outlook, our 2026E/27E/28E adj. EPS falls by 3%/34%/28%. We roll forward our target P/E multiple on Q5-Q8 EPS one quarter post earnings, and increase our target P/E multiple on Q5-Q8 EPS to 34.0x (from 30.5x) to account for higher market multiples, resulting in our 12-month price target decreasing 10% to $81 (from $90). We are Neutral-rated on CRCL.

Risks: Downside risks: Ecosystem growth slows; as a result of a weaker crypto market backdrop; Market share gains from USDT not continuing; Coinbase de-emphasizes USDC; and competition from other stable coins. Upside risks: favorable crypto regulation; further increases in crypto market cap; acceleration in market share gains from USDT; higher for longer rates benefiting reserve income.

CRCL	**$81.00**	**$76.12**	**6.4%**	

Neutral

Market cap: $20.4bn

3m ADV: $5.1bn

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Americas Banks and Diversified

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GS Forecast

	12/25	12/26E	12/27E	12/28E
Revenue ($ mn) New	**1,083.0**	**1,286.8**	**1,394.0**	**1,861.0**
Revenue ($ mn) Old	1,083.0	1,301.7	1,679.4	2,248.7
EPS ($) New	**1.33**	**1.59**	**1.61**	**2.67**
EPS ($) Old	1.33	1.63	2.45	3.71
P/E (X)	101.4	48.0	47.3	28.5
P/B (X)	4.6	4.8	4.5	4.1
ROA (%)	0.6	0.5	0.4	0.5
ROE (%)	18.8	11.7	10.5	16.0
Dividend yield (%)	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0

	9/26	12/26E	3/27E	6/27E
EPS ($)	0.80	0.16	0.36	0.33

Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Research estimates, FactSet. Price as of 4 Nov 2026 close.

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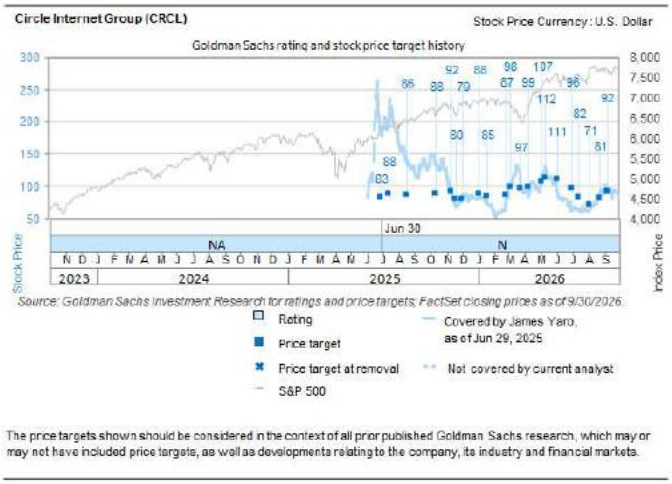
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Circle Internet Group (CRCL)

Date of report	Target price ($)	Closing price ($)
07-Oct-26	90.00	80.84
08-Sep-26	92.00	96.18
24-Aug-26	81.00	87.72
05-Aug-26	71.00	63.28
15-Jul-26	82.00	65.69
02-Jul-26	96.00	64.62
04-Jun-26	111.00	90.54
12-May-26	112.00	123.65
05-May-26	107.00	114.19
08-Apr-26	99.00	94.44
26-Mar-26	97.00	98.27
05-Mar-26	98.00	105.74
26-Feb-26	87.00	87.21
20-Jan-26	85.00	72.70
05-Jan-26	88.00	84.80
04-Dec-25	79.00	87.46
20-Nov-25	80.00	66.93
13-Nov-25	92.00	82.34
14-Oct-25	88.00	134.46
18-Aug-25	86.00	141.58
15-Jul-25	88.00	195.33
30-Jun-25	83.00	181.29

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